DECLINE OF THE GUNS

It was the Japanese strike on Pearl Harbor that first fully realized the potential of the aircraft carrier. Soon Japan and the United States were fighting naval battles conducted by shipborne aircraft at ranges of several hundred miles. In the Carrier Task Force, surface ships became escort screens for carriers, providing anti-aircraft and anti-submarine defense. Meanwhile submarines, as well as sinking a lot of warships, proved again their effectiveness as commerce raiders, especially for Germany in the Atlantic and the United States in the Pacific—although even submarines proved vulnerable to air power.

Whether under, on, or over the ocean surface, there was no doubting the importance of sea power in World War II. The Allies established dominance over the Atlantic, Mediterranean, and Pacific only after epic struggles. Amphibious operations, both landings and evacuations, were carried out on an unprecedented scale—the big guns of the battleships and cruisers proved above all important for shore bombardment in support of landings. The Allies won the race for technological development, with crucial progress in the use of radar, plus increasingly sophisticated systems of command and control, and superior naval intelligence. But the key to Allied success, in the end, was the astonishing productive power of American shipyards. By the end of the war the US Navy had not only crushed its enemies, but established an overwhelming superiority over its Allies.



Soviet submariner's uniform
The focus of the Soviet Navy during the Cold War was on matching the nuclear submarine and missile capacity of the United States.

COLD WAR AND AFTER

The context for the development of navies in the 40 years after World War II was the Cold War confrontation between the United States and the Soviet Union. The US Navy had to prepare for a possible nuclear war with the Soviets and to counter what America regarded as communist expansionism around the globe. The navy enjoyed the resources made available by American economic dominance, always the ultimate basis for naval power. But the USSR was prepared to devote a large percentage of its lesser national wealth to military development and thus over time created the world's second largest navy, a massive force especially strong in nuclear submarines. However, as a war between the two superpowers was ruled out by nuclear weapons, which made an all-out armed struggle between them in practice unwinnable, the Soviet Navy never fired a shot in anger. The US Navy by contrast saw plenty of action during the Cold War, notably in support of land operations in "limited" wars in Korea and Vietnam. Britain became America's subordinate ally, the Royal Navy still the third-largest naval force in the



Hunter-killer submarine
The Los Angeles-class nuclear-powered submarine *Salt Lake City* on exercises in 2005. The class was introduced during the Cold War as hunter-killers to track, and if necessary destroy, Soviet ballistic missile submarines.

1922
Washington Naval Treaty places strict limits on tonnages of warships for major naval powers after World War I

1934
Japan announces intention to withdraw from the Naval Treaties

1935
Anglo-German naval agreement allows Germany to strengthen its fleet

1939
Britain and France declare war on Germany. Within hours, German U-boat sinks British cruise ship, marking the start of U-boat warfare in the Atlantic

1941
Attack by Japanese carrier aircraft on US fleet at Pearl Harbor brings US into WWII

1942
Battle of the Coral Sea is the first battle between fleets of carriers in which neither side's ships exchange direct fire or have visual contact with opposing fleet

1944
First kamikaze suicide attacks by Japanese aviators against Allied shipping

1950
The largest amphibious landing since WWII takes place at Inchon in Korea, supported by a United Nations backed force of 230 ships

1954
First nuclear powered submarine launched, USS *Nautilus*

1955
Soviet Union fires first submarine-launched ballistic missile

1960
Nuclear-powered submarine USS *Triton* completes first submerged circumnavigation of the globe

1964
US Congress approves war in Vietnam

1920 | 1930 | 1940 | 1950 | 1960



Night vision goggles
A pair of World War II night vision goggles for use on board submarines during secret missions.